The Method of the Consecration Rite

Pratiṣṭhāvidhi · Toh 1257 · Derge Tengyur
རབ་གནས་ཀྱི་ཆོ་གའི་ཚུལ།

The Method of the Consecration Rite, known in Sanskrit as the Pratiṣṭhāvidhi and in Tibetan as Rab gnas kyi cho ga'i tshul, is Toh 1257 in the Tengyur, where it is placed among the commentaries and ritual works on the tantras. It is a concise tantric ritual manual on consecration, the rite by which images, stūpas, temples, books, rosaries and even wells and springs are made into sacred supports inhabited by the wisdom being. After an etymology of the word consecration and a classification of its objects as embodiments of enlightened body, speech and mind, it sets out the elaborate rite in sequence, with the preparatory day, the ritual bathing, the opening of the eyes and the enthroning of the image, followed by a condensed one-day version and a warning that offerings made to an unconsecrated image bear no fruit. Its colophon attributes it to the great paṇḍita Kṛṣṇa.

In the language of India: pratiṣṭha bidhi nāma. In the language of Tibet: The Method of the Consecration Rite.

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

By way of etymology, classification,
and the rite set out in sequence, I shall explain consecration.

First, the etymology. It is called prakaśaṇanādi pratiṣṭha: because it abides supremely, it is called consecration. Moreover, it is supreme because it is long-lasting, and supreme because it has become distinguished. Of these, "long-lasting" refers to all the supreme ones; "having become distinguished" refers to all the supreme abodes, because they have been made into the nature of the wisdom being.

Classification is twofold: classification by basis and classification by rite. Classification by basis is threefold: consecration as the embodiment of body, consecration as the embodiment of speech, and consecration as the embodiment of mind. Consecration as the embodiment of body applies to stūpas, temples, standing stones, trees, wells, springs, ponds, gateways and wooden pillars. Consecration as the embodiment of speech applies to rosaries, worldly books and books that transcend the world. Consecration as the embodiment of the individual families means that images are consecrated as

whatever their own respective body is. Classification by rite is into the elaborate rite and the condensed one.

Now I shall explain the rite set out in sequence. The master who performs the consecration should do it in an auspicious month, on an auspicious lunar date, under an auspicious planet and constellation. As it is said:

The six months and the four planets,
whichever are the fourteen constellations,
and the number of the seven lunar dates:
these are for the consecration of the Victor and the rest.

At those times, in a pleasing place, adorned with a canopy, curtains, banners and the like, one strews flowers and makes it fragrant. In that place one builds a single pedestal two cubits high and four cubits wide, square, even and beautiful, smooth, with four corners and without unevenness. It is made of stone, or of bricks and tiles, and is whitewashed with lime. On that pedestal one performs the bathing, the offerings and so forth for the deity to be consecrated.

The sequence of the rite is as follows. First, the image is seated on the pedestal facing east, and it is dressed in a yellow cloth with the mantra oṃ vajra vasta hūṃ. Then the auspicious water with white mustard seed, over which hūṃ has been recited, is circled three times from right and left and thrown into the fire, and so it is thoroughly purified. Then one places the five products of the cow together with the five nectars in a bowl, takes them up with a sprinkler of dūrvā grass, and washes the image with this mantra: oṃ sarva tathāgata kāya viśodhani svāhā.

Then, when it has been purified, one places sesame oil scented with fragrances in a bronze vessel, takes it up with the dūrvā sprinkler and, reciting the mantra, anoints the whole body well, with oṃ hūṃ traṃ hrīḥ khaṃ. Then, to remove the sesame oil, one washes it with water mixed with the powder of the five barks. Then again one anoints it with a cleansing paste of āmalaka and the like, and gives it the empowerment bath with vases of pure water mixed with the five nectars, reciting verses of auspiciousness, ringing the bell, sounding songs, dances and music with many cymbals, and pouring the water from the vases.

At that time the master imagines that in the sky the buddhas and bodhisattvas, the accomplished vidyādharas, and many gods and goddesses are also pouring water of nectar, and, reciting this mantra together with the

verse, he empowers and bathes it:

Just as, the very moment he was born,
all the tathāgatas bathed him
with the pure water of the gods,
so do I perform this bath.

oṃ sarva tathāgata abhiṣeka samaya śrī hūṃ āḥ svāhā. Then one wipes off well with a red cloth the water clinging to the body. This is the rite of bathing.

Then, with a scented paste of the two sandalwoods, saffron, lagu and krandeka, one anoints the heart of the deity, reciting this mantra: oṃ vajra gandhe āḥ svāhā. Then one offers flowers, incense, lamps, scented water and food offerings, each with its own mantra. With the hand holding the vajra one touches the heart, the throat, the crown and the shoulders three times. Holding incense in the hand, planting the right knee firmly on the ground, and making one's tongue into a vajra arisen from hūṃ, one should say the following three times, in order to establish the preparatory rite:

Blessed One, Vajra So-and-so,
king of knowledge, I bow to you and praise you.
Out of love for the students,
and in order to make offerings to you,
O protector whose very nature is compassion,
tomorrow the consecration will be performed.
To me, who am devoted, and to the pledge,
it is fitting that the Blessed One show kindness.
Grant to beings the aims of the wheel's activity.
Buddhas, think of me.
Arhats and bodhisattvas,
whatever other mantra deities there are,
gods and guardians of the world,
those who delight in the teaching,
in the awakening mind and in dependent arising,
and other beings possessing the vajra eye:
I, who perform the rite of great Vajradhara,
make offerings to this king of knowledge
as far as I am able,
and perform the consecration so that beings may be at peace.
To the excellent students and to me,

holding us close with your love,
all of you, being loving,
please grant permission for this consecration.

By saying this, one imagines that all the buddhas of the ten directions and the rest have come into the sky above that place of consecration.

Then the basis to be consecrated is meditated on as emptiness, and through the sequence of lotus, moon and so forth, according to the family, or else instantly from the seed syllable, it is generated as the deity. Then light rays issue from one's own heart and summon the wisdom being, and one imagines that it has come before one. With oṃ pratīccha arghaṃ hūṃ one offers water for welcome; with oṃ niriti hūṃ khaṃ one offers water to refresh the mouth; and with oṃ sarvva saṃśodhani hūṃ phaṭ one offers water to refresh the feet.

Again one offers flowers, incense, lamps, perfume, food and the sound of the bell, and with jaḥ hūṃ vaṃ hoḥ dissolves the wisdom being into the pledge being, confers empowerment and seals it. Again one offers flowers, incense, lamps, perfume, food and the music of cymbals, recites the mantra of that deity many times, and then requests the deity to depart with the hundred-syllable mantra together with muḥ. This is the rite of the preparatory stage.

Then, the next morning, at the place of the pedestal one arranges whatever offerings are available, together with a golden probe and collyrium, and performs the consecration. First the master, holding incense in his hand, planting the right knee firmly on the ground, and making his tongue into a vajra arisen from hūṃ, urges the deities by reciting the verses from "Blessed One" through "being loving" up to "please grant permission"; and here, in place of "tomorrow," one puts "today." Then one invites the wisdom being, offers the host of offerings such as water for welcome and water for the feet, and dissolves all the deities into the image. Again one makes offerings, and with oṃ vajra ābharaṇa vapuṣane svāhā one also offers whatever ornaments are available. Then one also offers praise. One opens the eyes with the golden probe smeared with collyrium, with this mantra, reciting: oṃ cakṣu samanta cakṣu viśodhani vajra svāhā. Then, saying dibya agne samādhi dhyana praṇani svāhā, one offers a little good food to the image in a copper vessel.

Then, reciting the mantra of Amṛtakuṇḍalin, with the right hand clenched one circles the vajra three times at the feet, the waist and the head of the image,

and so makes it stable. On top of the pedestal, on a throne one third the height of the image, not leaning too far forward, not leaning back, and not tilted, as beautifully as possible, one says pratiṣṭha vajra svāhā and sets it in place.

Then the words addressed to the student are:

The images that you
requested of me, in particular,
have been consecrated as it was taught:
this I have now done.
Since you have it perfectly complete,
make offerings to them as you please.

The student, for his part, offers to the image whatever is available, praises it, and circumambulates it many times. Then the master gives torma and makes supplication to the guardians who protect the Dharma, so that the image may be full of blessing and auspicious, and may remain for a long time. If one has the means, after offering food in a copper vessel one should perform an elaborate fire offering. This is the elaborate consecration.

The condensed consecration is completed in a single day, without performing the preparatory stage, with the bathing and the rest as described above. For books, paintings, clay reliefs and the like, one bathes a mirror. Cast images and the like are bathed directly. In a temple, one bathes as many images of deities as there are; it is not done all together in a general way. Stūpas, standing stones, gateways, trees and temples are accomplished as Vairocana. Springs, wells and the like are consecrated as Vairocana, and then, from his transformation at the end, they are consecrated as the spring and so forth. Rosaries for mantra recitation and books are made into Amitābha. If one draws a maṇḍala for the purpose of a consecration, the deity being consecrated should be made the principal figure. For a temple, or where many images reside, one should draw a maṇḍala with Vairocana as the principal figure.

If one asks what fault there is if the consecration is not performed:

Prostrating and making offerings
to an image that has not been consecrated
bears no fruit, like a fire offering
made into ashes without mantra.

That is the fault of not performing it.

The profound method of the consecration rite, composed by the great paṇḍita, the venerable Kṛṣṇa, is complete.

Translator's Notes

• "Lagu" and "krandeka" (Tibetan □□□□ and □□□□□□□□□) are aromatic ingredients that could not be identified with confidence and are given in phonetic form. Although the classification announces consecration of body, speech and mind, the third item is phrased as consecration "as the embodiment of the individual families"; it is translated as written. "Vajra So-and-so" stands for the name of the particular deity being consecrated, to be supplied by the officiant.
• In the instruction for the consecration of springs and wells, "from his transformation at the end" is a literal rendering of a terse phrase; the sense appears to be that the Vairocana visualization is finally transformed into the spring or well itself.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.